

Topic Freewrite: When you freewrite you write **continuously** for a specific amount of time, about a specific topic. You do not worry about spelling or grammar, you write whatever comes to mind and you **do not stop** until time is up.

1. **Set a timer and freewrite for 15 minutes.** Write about a topic/question/problem you would like to understand and why. What draws you to this topic? Why do you care about it? Why should other people care about it?

I find myself ruminating over a commonality that I see with nearly all of the conversations, arguments, and debates that I have ever been involved in, whether it was online or offline. In most cases, someone will present a verifiable fact (a piece of evidence) and the opposing individual will either: i) deny that the evidence exists; ii) question the validity of the evidence presented by the other party; iii) become more entrenched in their belief than before; or iv) show no willingness to concede at all. I have found myself staring in disbelief and wondering how this is possible given the obvious evidence that is available to support a particular view.

This matters because I truly believe that it is the underlying reason for many of the large-scale problems occurring today. From denial about science, to people refusing to take medicine, to the political environment that is tearing families and nations apart, to misinformation traveling faster than truth ever has, all of these issues connect back to one stubborn human behavior. If we can figure this out, perhaps the dialogue will go somewhere for once.

However, what really frightens me is that apparently, the act of correcting someone who holds incorrect information may actually make them believe it MORE?! This is truly

frightening. It means that the obvious solution of presenting people with the facts does not work. In fact, it may actually backfire completely. Therefore, what does work? Building trust before providing information? Using storytelling versus providing statistical data? We know people do change sometime...

Identity plays an enormous role in this area. When something you believe is no longer just something you believe – but is rather a fundamental aspect of who you are – (i.e., your group, your community, your people), then having someone challenge that belief becomes a personal attack. You hear “the fact is incorrect” but what you really hear is that the foundation upon which your entire world was built is possibly unstable. And the social consequences of accepting that reality are quite harsh – losing friends, losing a sense of belonging, losing yourself. So in a strange sort of way, being irrational is actually a form of rationality.

The internet clearly exacerbates the problem. Algorithms feed you exactly what you already believe. Everyone around you is nodding in agreement. When everyone around you agrees with you, it is very difficult to imagine walking away from that feeling of confirmation, and in some cases, it is even considered treasonous to question it.

At the same time, I am equally fascinated by the opposite end of the spectrum. People do leave the groups they have been a part of for decades. People do come to accept what they previously were unwilling to accept. What is it that makes those moments

different? Was it the words of a trusted individual at the right time? Did a single event occur that shattered everything? Or did the doubts creep up slowly, quietly until they finally became unmanageable and forced themselves into awareness?

- 2. Reread what you have written and reflect.** Was it easy to write about this topic for an extended period of time? Is this a valuable topic for research? Is it a topic you would want to spend an entire semester on?

Finding ideas and connecting concepts seemed easy enough while writing this. As I wrote I could see how psychology, technology, and philosophy all connected in ways that I couldn't see at first. I never really felt stuck or as if I needed to stop anytime soon.

It does seem like an area of value for research; there are many other scholars working on related topics, however, there is still a great deal of room for further study. Especially since most people are using some form of digital media today. The potential for a focused question such as "What communication strategies will reach someone who has firmly established a false belief?", seems like something that is relevant and very important right now.

I would definitely devote my entire semester to this. Absolutely no questions about that.